



Summary of Changes

Overview

The Chapter's 2016 bylaws, still in force today, run only a few pages and leave most of governance unwritten: no written process to remove an officer, no due-process floor beyond expulsion, no endorsement rules, no emergency limits, few financial controls, a flat six-person quorum, and five required member meetings a year. After the recovery, the Chapter wrote a comprehensive revision that closed those gaps but grew to about 19,300 words, longer than the bylaws of any comparable chapter. The proposed lean bylaws keep the protections that revision added and cut the document to about 12,300 words, roughly a thirty-six percent reduction, by moving operating detail into the Codes, Rules, and Policies below them.

Nothing the membership relies on is given up. Two of the five changes described below trim in one direction, and the membership should weigh them: the temporary suspension penalty, new since 2016, may run to one year where the revision capped it at six months, and routine Rule votes take seven days notice rather than ten. Beyond those, no right, protection, threshold, quorum, or due-process step is reduced. Five things change in substance and are described below; everything else carries over unchanged, and this summary shows where the relocated detail now lives.

Protections that carry over

Every member right and protection in the revised bylaws carries into the lean bylaws unchanged. The core of them, with the numbers that give them force:

- **Membership.** Every National DSA member who lives or works in the sixteen-county service territory is a member, and any National DSA member may voluntarily affiliate. Chapter dues are voluntary and never a condition of membership, voting, or office. Caucuses, factions, and open critique of Chapter or national leadership are protected and can never be grounds for discipline.
- **Meetings.** General Meetings at least monthly and an Annual Convention each July, all hybrid by right: a remote member is counted toward quorum and votes with the same effect as one in the room, a floor the Steering Committee cannot condition, narrow, or withhold. No proxy voting. Any five members can force an item onto a General Meeting agenda, and Steering Committee meetings are open to all members.
- **Quorum.** Five percent of the membership, never fewer than six, for ordinary actions; ten percent, never fewer than twelve, for the nine heightened actions described below. The

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certified membership count and both quorum numbers are published with every meeting notice.

- **Elections.** The 2016 nomination rules carry forward: nominations open thirty days before an election, close five days before, and members may nominate themselves. Contested elections are by secret ballot, no candidate administers their own election, and delegates to National are elected by the Scottish Single Transferable Vote. Voting in an election takes thirty days of good standing; voting on motions takes none.
- **Officer accountability.** All five officers serve one-year terms without pay, hold one office each, and stand for election every year. An officer can be removed for cause by heightened action on twenty-one days written notice, with the grounds stated and a right to respond and be heard, and twenty members or ten percent of the Chapter, whichever is fewer, can petition the removal question onto the agenda, where the Steering Committee cannot block or delay it. A vacancy is filled by interim appointment within fourteen days, and the membership confirms or rejects the interim within forty-five days unless the regular annual election arrives first. An officer who files for public office must resign unless the membership waives it.
- **Discipline.** Only the membership can suspend or expel: suspension by ordinary action, expulsion by heightened action, each on twenty-one days written notice with the charges and the evidence, a written response, the right to appear with witnesses and an advisor, a written decision within fourteen days, and appeal reaching the National Political Committee. A political expulsion is decided by the membership, never by a grievance officer. The Steering Committee alone can impose nothing heavier than a warning, mediation, or required training, apart from an appealable temporary protective measure while a grievance is pending.
- **Grievances.** Harassment and conduct complaints go to elected Harassment Grievance Officers under the DSA Unified Grievance Policy, at least one at all times and at least two once the Chapter passes one hundred members, and no minimum membership time is required to file.
- **Endorsements.** An electoral endorsement is decided only by the membership, as a heightened action on fourteen days notice. The Steering Committee may take solidarity and coalition action between meetings, but the membership can rescind or redirect any of it by ordinary action, and no officer can commit the Chapter alone.
- **Emergencies.** A declared emergency must be in writing, state its trigger, and be communicated within forty-eight hours. It cannot expel a member, remove an officer, amend the bylaws, change any Code or Rule, or endorse; it expires after ninety days unless the membership extends it by heightened action, and the membership can end it early by ordinary action.
- **Money.** The Treasurer and both Co-Chairs are the account signatories, the membership adopts the annual budget, spending above the set thresholds and any unbudgeted payment

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to a person requires a General Meeting, and any member can demand the Chapter's latest annual financial statements as Tennessee law provides.

- **Records and privacy.** Members keep the statutory right to inspect Chapter records, and no Code, Rule, or Policy may disclose member home addresses or the identities on event sign-in sheets except as the law requires or the person consents.

The offices are the same five as the revision: two Co-Chairs, a Secretary, a Treasurer, and a Steward, who together are the Steering Committee and serve as the Chapter's board of directors under the Tennessee Nonprofit Corporation Act, running the Chapter between General Meetings. The Steward leads onboarding, retention, and political education and maintains the roster; the Secretary certifies the membership count behind every quorum. Several of these protections are declaratory floors: rights drawn from Tennessee statute and the national documents that the bylaws restate but do not create; they would survive even a repeal, and no Code, Rule, or Policy can reduce them.

Operating detail moved to the tiers

The bulk of the reduction is relocation. Detailed procedures that were written into the bylaws now live in the tier instruments below them: twenty named in the bylaws and three more created under the Chapter's general tier powers, twenty-three in all.

- the **Codes** (Tier 2, the entrenched frameworks) carry the Chapter Code of Conduct, the Discipline Code, the Whistleblower Code, the Conflict of Interest Code, the Information Security Code, the Compliance Code, the Code on Election Procedures, the Financial Controls Code, and the Document Retention Code;
- the **Rules** (Tier 3, the ordinary operating law) carry the officer, meeting, and Annual Convention procedures, subsidiary-body operations, endorsement procedures, accessibility and accommodations, the emergency mechanics, Harassment Grievance Officer operations, and records classification and public disclosure, among others;
- the **Policies** (Tier 4, Steering Committee administration subject to membership override) carry the administrative registers, including the registry and version control of every instrument and the compliance calendar.

The most important subjects are reserved to the Code tier, so they cannot be weakened by a Rule or Policy. Moving a procedure out of the bylaws does not put it beyond the membership's reach: every Code and Rule is still adopted and amended by the membership, every Policy is subject to a membership override, and until an instrument is adopted, existing Chapter practice on its subject continues under the bylaws' savings clause, so nothing lapses in the gap. The companion Member's Guide and Governance Instruments Catalog describe what each instrument governs and what it does not.

Member control across the four tiers

- **Tier 1, the Bylaws**, the hardest law to change, amended only through the Article XX process described below.
- **Tier 2, the Codes**, adopted or amended over two consecutive General Meetings: the first debates and advances the text by majority vote, and the second takes the final vote on identical text at the higher quorum and a two-thirds supermajority.
- **Tier 3, the Rules**, adopted or amended by majority vote at a single General Meeting on seven days written notice.
- **Tier 4, the Policies**, adopted by the Steering Committee but always subject to override: the membership may rescind any Policy or direct its amendment by majority vote, and a rescinded Policy may not return in similar form for twelve months without the membership's leave.

Below the four binding tiers sit Artifacts, the non-binding logs, registers, and forms that carry out the work of a tier document; an Artifact binds no one and is corrected, not followed, if it conflicts with the instrument above it. Alongside the tiers, and not one of them, sit the Chapter's own acts: motions, which may be styled Resolutions when written out. A motion decides one question once and binds to the extent of its terms, but it never becomes standing law. Across all tiers the rule is the same: the higher tier controls, and nothing at any tier can reduce a right, threshold, quorum, or protection the bylaws fix.

Ordinary and heightened actions

The lean bylaws give a name to something the thresholds already imply: every decision made at a meeting of the whole Chapter is one of two kinds. An **ordinary action** is the everyday case, decided at the ordinary quorum by a simple majority. A **heightened action** is one of exactly nine decisions the bylaws single out as consequential enough to demand more: amending the bylaws, adopting or changing a Code, expelling a member, removing an officer or a Harassment Grievance Officer, dissolving the Chapter, making an electoral endorsement, waiving the resignation requirement for an officer who files for public office, and extending or re-declaring an emergency. Each of the nine requires both the higher quorum and a two-thirds supermajority, with no exceptions and no tenth case. Where the bylaws say a decision is taken by heightened action, that phrase is shorthand for that pair of requirements. Elections keep their own ballot methods, each action keeps its own notice period, and no vote of a single General Meeting, however large, can suspend or override a Code, which changes only through its two-meeting process.

The five substantive changes

Five provisions change the Chapter's governance in substance rather than simply relocating existing text. Each is set out below so the membership can weigh it before voting.

A more open amendment process

Any five members in good standing may propose a bylaws amendment at any time of year, without routing it through the Steering Committee (Article XX). The Secretary circulates the proposal to the full membership within thirty days, performs a technical check within fifteen days with no power to weigh substance or merit, and must circulate the proposal even if the proposers decline every suggested correction; the Steering Committee may not screen, filter, delay, or block it. The proposal is debated at a General Meeting where no vote is taken, then adopted only by two supermajority votes at the higher quorum on identical text, each on at least fourteen days written notice, with germane floor amendments allowed only at the first voting meeting. Against the 2016 bylaws the Chapter votes under today, the trade runs both ways: any five members can now reach the full membership directly, and the bar to change rises from a simple majority at two consecutive meetings to a two-thirds supermajority at the higher quorum at both.

Lapse and dissolution of subsidiary bodies

A Branch, Standing Committee, or Working Group that goes inactive may lapse, but only after written notice to its members and a cure window in which it can resume activity, and the membership may dissolve a body by majority vote on a noticed agenda item, with notice and a chance to be heard and no Steering Committee recommendation needed (Article VIII). The Youth Section is exempt from both: it exists whenever eligible members organize and is dormant when they do not. A closed body's funds return to the general fund, its records pass to the Secretary, and its members remain full members of the Chapter.

Motions and Resolutions named, bounded, and enforced

The 2016 bylaws never say what a motion is or what it does once the meeting ends. The lean bylaws name the category and set its limits in one place (Article XVIII, Section 9). A motion is a single decision on a single question; put in formal written form it may be styled a Resolution, the word most members already use and the word National DSA uses for the acts of its convention. Styling a motion a Resolution changes nothing about its effect. A motion binds to the extent of its terms, but no motion becomes standing law: it cannot create a continuing rule, procedure, or

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standard outside the four tiers, and it is void so far as it conflicts with the bylaws or with any adopted Code, Rule, or Policy.

Section 9 mostly names and consolidates existing practice, but it adds one rule of its own: a motion is now expressly void so far as it conflicts with the bylaws or with any adopted Code, Rule, or Policy. The enforcement side then makes that voidness bite (Article XIX, Sections 2 and 3). An action taken against a Policy was already null and void, but an action taken against a motion of the whole membership, including one styled a Resolution, was not, which left an act of the membership less enforceable than an administrative measure the Steering Committee adopts on its own. That is corrected, with two limits kept deliberately narrow: the nullity reaches only a motion that directs or restrains someone after the meeting ends, so the bare decision to endorse, take a position, commend, or recess falls outside it, and it runs only so far as the body that adopted the motion had authority to bind that officer, body, or member. The bylaws also now say who determines that an action is void, which they never did for any tier. It is the Secretary, who already keeps the Chapter's governance records, acting on their own initiative or on a member's written request answered within fourteen days. The determination records a nullity that already exists rather than creating one, so no action waits on it. It is not discipline and cannot ground discipline or removal without separate charges under the Articles that govern those. The Steward decides instead where the action is the Secretary's own, is the act of a body the Secretary took part in, is one in which the Secretary would be conflicted under the Conflict of Interest Code, or that office is vacant; where the Steward is likewise disqualified, any other officer who is not disqualified decides, and where no officer can act the question goes straight to the membership. Any member may take a determination, a refusal to make one, or the underlying question to the membership, which settles it by majority vote.

Notice periods for routine business

Rules, and the Policy membership-override vote, move from ten days written notice to seven, matching the ordinary General Meeting agenda notice already required for those single-meeting, majority-vote actions; the difference between a Rule and a Code is carried by the vote threshold, not by extra notice days.

A longer maximum suspension

The 2016 bylaws allow only expulsion; the bounded temporary suspension is a penalty the revision introduced, and the lean bylaws keep it but raise its ceiling from six months to one year (Article XII, Section 2). This is the one change that narrows a protection the revision would have set. The safeguards do not change: a suspension is imposed only by the membership, by ordinary action on twenty-one days written notice with the full due-process protections of Article XII, and the separate protective measure the Steering Committee may impose while a

grievance is pending stays capped by the national Unified Grievance Policy's limit, currently 120 days, which the Chapter cannot lengthen.

The purpose of a shorter rulebook

A rulebook only protects the Chapter if members can read it and keep it current. Detail written into the bylaws freezes: a drafting error there can be fixed only by full amendment, while the same procedure in a Code or Rule can be corrected without reopening the bylaws, and nothing below the bylaws can reduce what they fix.

The ratification timeline

The lean bylaws are adopted under the amendment procedure of the 2016 bylaws in effect today, not under the new Article XX process, which governs future amendments once these bylaws take effect. Under that 2016 procedure, the membership takes a first approving vote at the August 24, 2026 General Meeting and a second and final vote at the September 28, 2026 General Meeting, by majority vote at each.

The lean bylaws take effect on the announcement of that second vote. The subordinate Codes, Rules, and Policies are then adopted on their own schedule, in dependency order: the framework Policies first, the Rules across the fall of 2026, and the Codes two at a time into the spring of 2027, with the Rule on Records Classification and Public Disclosure last because it waits on outside counsel. The full meeting-by-meeting schedule is kept in the Sub-Document Adoption Timeline.

Members are encouraged to read this summary and the full text, to bring questions and proposed changes to the discussion, and to vote at both meetings. A one-page overview is in the companion TL;DR, the Member's Guide and Governance Instruments Catalog explain the instruments, and where this summary and the bylaws differ, the bylaws govern.